Clinical Simulation for Student Role Playing Physiotherapist

Falls & Frailty – BSc Physiotherapy

Student Role: Physiotherapist

Patient: Mrs XYZ, 78 years

Diagnosis: Recurrent Falls with Frailty

Presentation: 3 falls in 6 months

Patient Scenario

Mrs XYZ is a 78-year-old patient referred to physiotherapy following three falls in the past six months.

She has:
- A history of frailty
- Polypharmacy
- Reduced quadriceps strength
- Poor balance
- Significant fear of falling
- Reduced confidence with walking
- Reduced functional mobility

She currently:
- Walks slowly indoors
- Avoids going outside alone
- Uses furniture for support
- Reports feeling “unstable” when turning

She is medically stable and able to communicate clearly.

Your Role as the Physiotherapist

During this clinical simulation, you are expected to:

☐ Introduce yourself and gain consent
☐ Carry out a structured subjective assessment
☐ Select and justify appropriate outcome measures
☐ Perform a focused and safe objective assessment
☐ Explain your clinical reasoning
☐ Develop a safe and appropriate management plan

Safety Guidelines

☐ Stay close during standing and walking
☐ Do not rush the patient
☐ Ensure clear environment (remove hazards)
☐ Reassure throughout
☐ Prioritise safety over performance

1. Introduction & Consent

Student Task

Write 1–2 key points you would include when introducing yourself and explaining the session to the patient.

Notes:

Hints:

- Clear introduction
- Explain what you will assess
- Reassure a fearful patient
- Emphasise safety

2. Subjective Assessment

Student Task

Write at least TWO subjective questions you would ask the patient and document their answers.

Question 1: Answer:

Question 2: Answer:

(Optional) Question 3: Answer:

Hints to Guide Question Choice

Think about asking questions related to:

- Circumstances of previous falls
- Dizziness or blackouts
- Medication changes
- Fear of falling
- Activities avoided
- Environmental hazards at home
- What the patient wants to regain

Ask yourself: How will this question guide my assessment or treatment plan?

3. Objective Assessment

You are now asked to assess the patient safely.

Safety Rules

- Stay close during standing tasks
- Guard appropriately
- Stop if unsafe
- Do not challenge beyond ability

Student Task

Select and justify at least TWO outcome measures:

Outcome Measure 1: Why chosen?

Outcome Measure 2: Why chosen?

Possible measures include:

- Clinical Frailty Scale
- Falls Risk Assessment Tool
- Timed Up and Go (TUG)
- 30-second Chair Stand
- Berg Balance Scale

Observation Section

Standing posture:

Balance in standing:

Sit-to-stand ability:

Walking:

Turning:

4. Clinical Reasoning

Student Task

Briefly explain:

Why is this patient at risk of falling?

Consider:

- Frailty
- Muscle weakness
- Polypharmacy
- Balance impairment
- Fear-avoidance cycle

Explanation:

5. Initial Management Plan

Part A – Treatment Aims

Aim 1:

Aim 2:

Aim 3 (optional):

Hints:

- Improve lower limb strength
- Improve balance
- Reduce falls risk
- Increase confidence
- Improve safe mobility

Part B – Exercise & Falls Prevention Plan

Write and briefly explain 2–3 components of your management plan:

1.
2.
3.

Possible hints for the exercises:

- Sit-to-stand strengthening
- Progressive balance training
- Environmental advice
- Medication liaison
- Confidence building strategies
- Graded exposure to walking

6. Safety & Escalation

If the patient falls again next week:

What would you do?

Think about:

- Reassessment
- GP communication
- MDT referral
- Medication review
- Safeguarding

End-of-Session Reflection

What is the most important learning point in this case?